

Electoral Rhetoric and Democratic Norms

Research-assistant contribution | University of Texas at Austin | Summer 2024

A public summary of my contribution to a faculty-led research project on how candidates communicate after electoral victory and defeat. The broader research question, analysis, and any eventual findings are not presented as my independent scholarship.

QUESTION AND APPROACH

The project assembled structured evidence across presidential, congressional, and gubernatorial elections from 2000 through 2024. My work combined official election results, public statements, transcript and news-source verification, and a consistent qualitative coding protocol for victory, concession, recount, and litigation contexts.

CONTRIBUTION

I built and quality-checked candidate-level records; documented party, incumbency, vote share, margin, and winner/loser status; located public victory and concession statements; and coded approximately 100 statements for indicators including unity appeals, references to democracy, voter-fraud claims, recounts, litigation, and communication with opposing candidates.

SELECTED TAKEAWAYS

- Credible comparative research depends on definitions, source trails, and consistent coding decisions that another researcher can audit.
- Turning scattered election results, speeches, and reporting into structured fields creates research infrastructure; it does not transfer ownership of the faculty-led research agenda or its conclusions.
- The public brief describes methods and responsibilities without releasing the project workbook, source-level coding decisions, or nonpublic research material.

SKILLS DEMONSTRATED

- Election research, dataset construction, source verification, qualitative coding, and spreadsheet quality control
- Research documentation, confidentiality judgment, deadline management, and careful distinction between contribution and authorship

Portfolio note: This brief describes Caleb's contribution only. The underlying dataset and broader project remain the faculty research team's work and are not publicly released.